

JAMES WILD & CO. · COSTA RICA · 9°56′N 84°05′W · SINCE 1991

Costa Rica, *the Long Way Round*

A field guide to Costa Rica's wildlife, rainforest lodges and wild coasts, from an explorer who first came in 1991

PREPARED FOR

Jane Traveler

TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

JAMES WILD & CO. · LEDGERED & VETTED · JOURNEY DESIGN SINCE 1982

COVER · THE PACIFIC COAST AT DUSK · GETTY IMAGES

A LETTER BEFORE YOU GO

Dear Jane,

I first came to Costa Rica in 1991 with a surfboard, a map that was mostly guesswork and a rental car that was mostly rust. After a few short jaunts to the Bahamas and selling my very first surf trip, this was where I branched out. We ran one of the first surf and adventure travel companies here, Adventure Expeditions, and we spent the early nineties finding and mapping the breaks, all the way up into Nicaragua and down into Panama. Later I worked as a wholesaler for many of the big travel brands, which is a polite way of saying I drove every bad road so their guests wouldn't have to.

We got stuck. A lot. We took the wrong turn so often it became the route. We drove into rivers and, more than once, never reached the other side. Small planes landed on dirt strips after someone ran out to shoo the cows off the runway. Before you sat down anywhere, you checked the rafters for hornet nests. It was raw, it was wild and it was very, very cheap.

Well, now. The roads are paved (mostly), the lodges are some of the finest in the Americas, and the price has caught up with the view. The waves, the forest and the people haven't changed a bit. That's why I keep going back, and why I still know which road not to take.

This guide is page one of your Folio. Mark it up. Circle what makes you grin. Cross out what doesn't. When we talk, I'll already know which kind of traveler you are.

J. Wild CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER · COSTA RICA SINCE 1991

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

	1991, when I first came	Today
VISITORS	About 504,000 international visitors	Nearly 2.95 million (2025)
THE WAY IN	Dirt roads, river fords and a few grass airstrips	Two international airports, San José and Liberia, and paved roads to most coasts
THE PRICE	Raw and very inexpensive	Well, now...

How to read the marks in this guide

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

The places James has gone back to since 1991.

I KNOW A PLACE
I slept here

James has stayed or surfed there himself.

I KNOW WHO KNOWS
partner vetted

Vetted through a partner we trust.

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit

On James's list. Recommended, honestly marked.

IN THIS GUIDE

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Read it coast to coast, the way I learned it.

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Two oceans, one long afternoon apart



◀ PACIFIC · GUANACASTE, NICOYA, OSA

CARIBBEAN · TORTUGUERO, PUERTO VIEJO ▶



The local mascot. He does not do mornings either

A small country with a big address book

Costa Rica holds nearly 6% of the world's biodiversity on about 0.03% of its surface: rainforest, cloud forest, dry forest, mangrove and two oceans of reef, all within a day's drive.

Green on purpose

More than a quarter of the land is protected in national parks and reserves. The country abolished its army in 1948 and has spent the savings on schools, parks and, it sometimes seems, frogs.

Two oceans before lunch

The Pacific and the Caribbean are about four hours apart by road and forty minutes by small plane. Breakfast with howler monkeys, lunch with sea turtles. Very few countries can promise that, and fewer can keep it.

LINGER LONGER *"Costa Rica is small enough to cross in a day and big enough to keep surprising you for thirty-five years." — J. W.*

Dry, green, and everything in between

	J	F	M	A	M	J	J	A	S	O	N	D
Pacific, dry season	●	●	●	●	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	●
Caribbean coast	○	●	●	○	○	○	○	○	●	●	○	○
Green season, waterfalls	○	○	○	○	●	●	●	●	●	●	●	○
Quetzals, cloud forest	●	●	●	●	○	○	○	○	○	○	○	●
Turtles, Tortuguero	○	○	○	○	○	○	●	●	●	●	○	○
Humpbacks, Uvita	●	●	●	○	○	○	●	●	●	●	○	●
Ostional turtle arribadas	○	○	○	○	○	○	●	●	●	●	●	○

● Prime months ○ Possible, with more rain, wind or a smaller swell. Guidance only; nature keeps her own calendar.

DECEMBER – APRIL

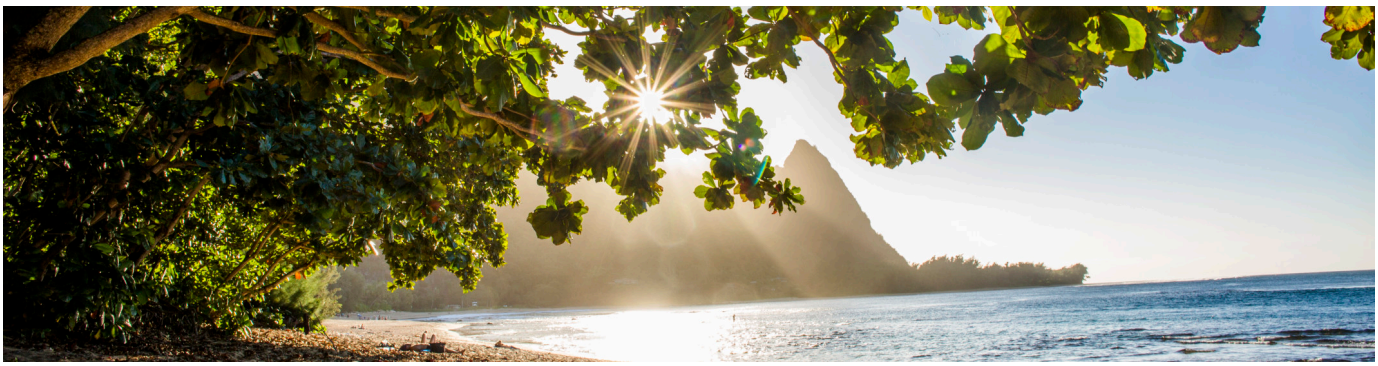
The dry season

Blue skies on the Pacific side, offshore winds in Guanacaste and the easiest roads. Also the busiest months, so book the good lodges early.

MAY – NOVEMBER

The green season

Sunny mornings, afternoon downpours, roaring waterfalls, turtles and whales, and fewer people everywhere. My favourite time, and the forest agrees.



Where the forest meets the Pacific

In 1992 the rainy season taught me the difference between a road and a river. The map can't tell you. I can.

– J. Wild

Who Costa Rica is for, and who it isn't

The short answer: almost everyone, as long as you don't mind a little rain and a lot of green. Here's how I'd match you, by the kind of traveler you are.

BEST FOR
Families, wildlife lovers, couples and anyone who likes a little mud with their luxury

IDEAL LENGTH
10 to 14 days: two coasts and the volcano

BEST TIME
Dec–Apr dry season; Jul–Oct for turtles and whales

HOW
Lodges and villas, linked by small plane and 4x4

MADE FOR YOU IF YOU'RE…

First-timers
Volcano, cloud forest, beach. The greatest hits, in the right order.
OUR PICK · TWO OCEANS, ONE VOLCANO · 12 DAYS

Birders & photographers
Over 900 species of bird, and every one of them faster than your shutter.
OUR PICK · MONTEVERDE, THEN THE OSA

Families with kids
Sloths before breakfast, ziplines after lunch, frogs at bedtime.
OUR PICK · NAYARA OR PACUARE, THEN THE BEACH

Couples & honeymooners
Seven rooms, a wood-fired hot tub and the howler monkeys as your alarm clock.
OUR PICK · ORIGINS LODGE

Wildlife lovers
Corcovado is the real thing. Tapirs, scarlet macaws, four kinds of monkey.
OUR PICK · LAPA RIOS, OSA PENINSULA

Wellness seekers
Hot springs at Arenal, yoga in Nosara, nothing on the calendar.
OUR PICK · NAYARA SPRINGS, THEN NOSARA

THINK TWICE IF YOU'RE…

Anyone in a hurry
The map says two hours. The road says four. Costa Rica agrees with the road.
OUR PICK · FLY BETWEEN REGIONS; STAY LONGER IN FEWER

Perfect-weather people
It's a rainforest. It rains. That's the deal.
OUR PICK · GO DECEMBER TO APRIL, PACIFIC SIDE

Big-city nightlife
Here, the night shift is frogs, fireflies and a tree full of howlers.
OUR PICK · TWO NIGHTS IN SAN JOSÉ, THEN OUT

Limited mobility
Muddy trails, river landings, tender boats.
OUR PICK · PAPAGAYO RESORTS AND GENTLER LODGES; TELL US AND WE'LL PLAN IT

Bug-phobic
Something will crawl past. It's probably harmless. Probably.
OUR PICK · DRY-SEASON GUANACASTE, SCREENED SUITES

Minimum ages for rafting, ziplines and some lodges apply `[confirm per property]`. If you're not sure where you fit, that's what the call is for.

III · THE WILDLIFE

Who you'll meet, and who to give space

Nearly six percent of the world's species live here. Most are delightful. A few deserve respect. All of them were here first.

THE ONES YOU WANT TO SEE

Two- and three-toed sloths · EVERYWHERE WITH TREES
Slower than the queue at Customs, and better company. Look for a shaggy football in the canopy.

Scarlet macaws · OSA, CARARA
You'll hear them before you see them: two macaws arguing sound exactly like a long marriage.

Resplendent quetzal · MONTEVERDE, SAN GERARDO DE DOTA
The bird the Maya held sacred. Best December to April; your guide will know which avocado tree.

Red-eyed tree frog · LOWLAND RAINFOREST, AT NIGHT
The country's unofficial mascot. Night walks only: he does not do mornings.

Humpback whales · MARINO BALLENA, UVITA, OSA
Two seasons of them, from north and south. Our captains know when to switch the engine off.

Sea turtles · TORTUGUERO, OSTIONAL, THE OSA
Green turtles nest at Tortuguero July to October. Red light only, voices down.

Keel-billed toucan · CARIBBEAN AND NORTHERN LOWLANDS
A banana with wings. Looks top-heavy, flies anyway.

Baird's tapir · CORCOVADO
Half pig, half elephant, all shy. If you see one, buy your guide dinner.

THE ONES YOU MAY SEE · BE WARNED

Terciopelo (fer-de-lance)
Venomous. Shy, but not forgiving. Stay on the trail, wear closed shoes and walk with a guide after dark.

White-faced capuchins
Clever, cute and criminal. They will take your lunch, your sunglasses and, given time, your passport.

American crocodiles
Lined up under the Tárcoles River bridge like a welcoming committee. Admire from the bridge; don't swim in river mouths.

Howler monkeys
The loudest land animal in the Americas, at 4.30 a.m., every day. Don't stand directly underneath. Trust me.

Bullet ants
Inch-long and named for how the sting feels. Watch where you put your hands on a trail.

Coatis
Raccoon's organised cousin. Travels in gangs, opens bags. Zip everything.

Hornets and wasps
My old friends from 1991. Check the rafters before you sit. Then sit.



Humpbacks off the south Pacific coast

HOW TO SEE MORE · FOUR HOUSE RULES

01 · EARLY
Dawn and dusk are rush hour. Midday is for the lodge pool.

02 · A GUIDE
A good naturalist spots a sloth from a moving car. You won't. Yet.

03 · LOOK UP
If three people are staring at a tree, stop. Something is in it.

04 · HANDS OFF
Never feed anything, especially the capuchins. They talk.

Wildlife sightings are never guaranteed, which is exactly why they're thrilling. Seasons are guidance; your naturalist has the final word.

III · AROUND THE CORNER

What Costa Rica will show you, if you let it

Thirty-five years of wrong turns taught me one thing: the best of this country is always just around the corner. A few of my favourites.

AROUND THE CORNER FROM THE TÁRCOLES BRIDGE

…thirty crocodiles posing for free. The best photo op that can also eat you.

AROUND THE CORNER FROM ARENAL

…a river hot enough for a bath, warmed by the volcano. Nature's jacuzzi, no booking required.

AROUND THE CORNER IN TENORIO

…the Río Celeste, where two rivers meet and turn sky-blue. It looks retouched. It isn't.

AROUND THE CORNER OF ANY TRAIL

…leaf-cutter ants carrying a forest across your path, one leaf at a time. Step over, never on.

AROUND THE CORNER AT NIGHT

…a glass frog. You can see its heart beating through its belly. Bring a headlamp and a sense of wonder.

AROUND THE CORNER OF EVERY LODGE

…a blue morpho butterfly, flashing electric blue like a camera going off in the forest.

AROUND THE CORNER OF THE MAIN ROAD

…a soda, a family kitchen with a casado better than most lodge dinners. Point, smile, eat.

AROUND THE CORNER IN THE HILLS

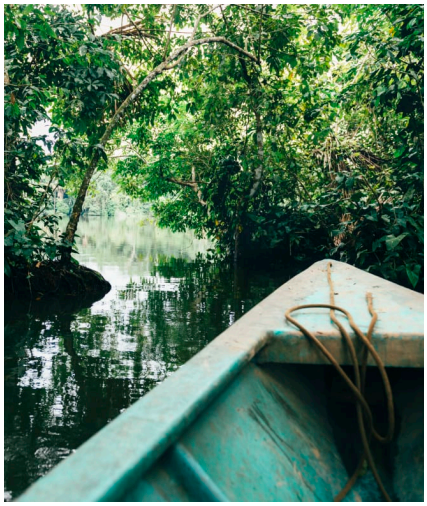
…coffee farms at Tarrazú and Naranjo. The best cup of your life, served by the person who picked it.

AROUND EVERY CORNER, ONCE A WEEK

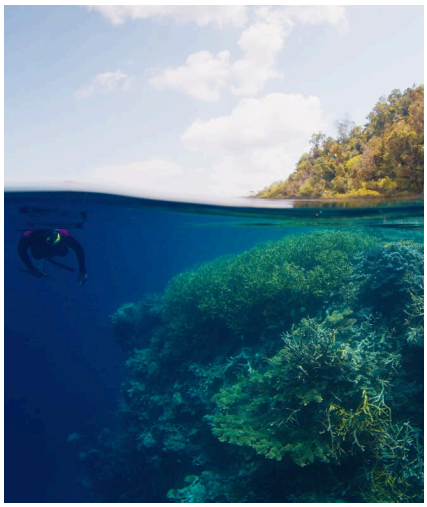
…a sloth climbing all the way down its tree for its weekly bathroom break. The bravest thing it does all week. Don't laugh; it's working hard.

AROUND THE LAST CORNER

…a Tico who answers every question, good news or bad, with "pura vida". By day three, so will you.



By boat, where the road gives up

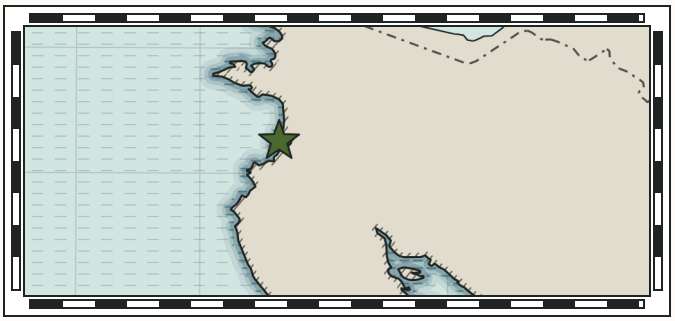


Above and below the waterline

If the road ends, ask the nearest Tico. If the Tico shrugs, you're in exactly the right place.

— J. Wild

Six regions, two oceans



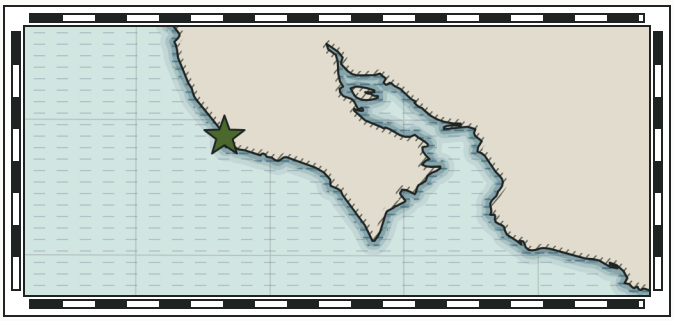
Guanacaste & Papagayo

The dry northwest

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Papagayo's sheltered bays, dry forest full of howlers, and Rincón de la Vieja's bubbling mud pots inland.

Bays & volcanoes · Four Seasons Papagayo



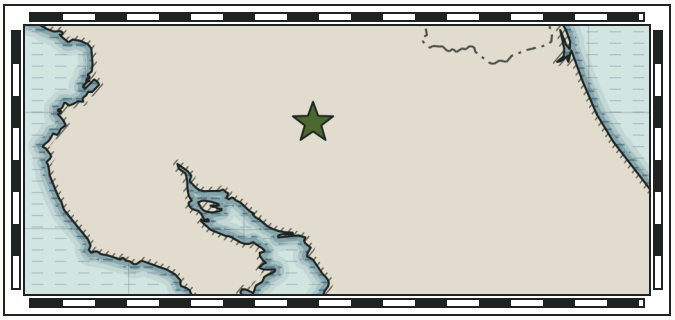
The Nicoya Peninsula

Nosara to Santa Teresa

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Blue Zone villages, yoga towns, nesting turtles at Ostional and long dirt roads between them.

Beaches & yoga · Harmony, Nosara



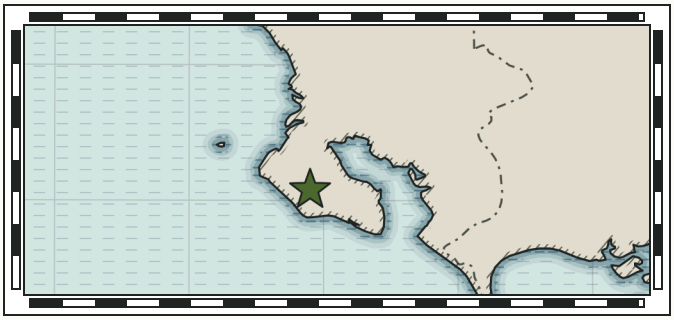
Arenal & the north

Volcano and hot springs

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit

The perfect cone of Arenal, hot rivers, hanging bridges and the cloud forest of Monteverde next door.

Springs & bridges · Nayara Springs



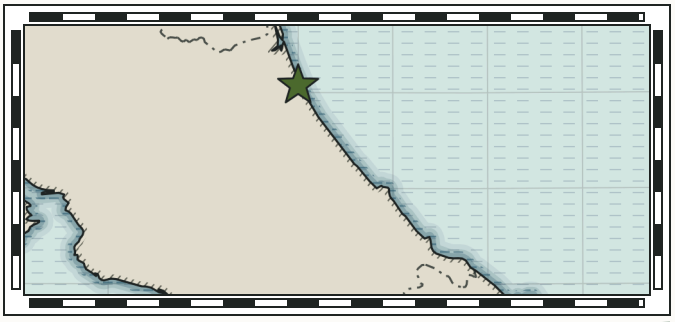
The Osa Peninsula

Corcovado

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit

The wildest corner: rainforest to the tideline, scarlet macaws, tapirs and humpbacks offshore.

Rainforest & whales · Lapa Rios



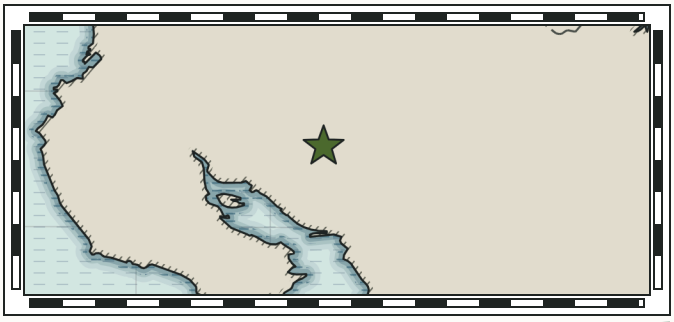
The Caribbean coast

Tortuguero to Puerto Viejo

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Turtle beaches and canals in the north; reggae, reef and sloth sanctuaries in the south.

Turtles & reef · Boat from La Pavona



Monteverde

The cloud forest

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991

Hanging bridges through the clouds, quetzals in the avocado trees and a night walk that will rearrange your idea of a frog.

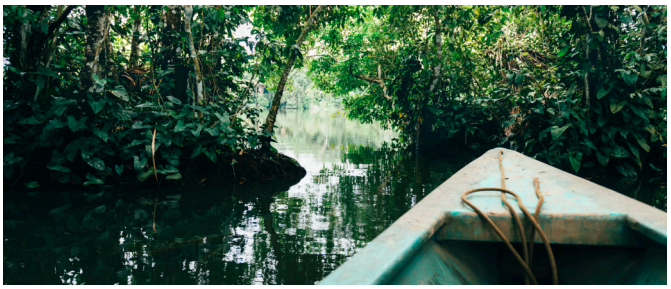
Bridges & birds · Day trip from Arenal

Sample stamps for layout. James confirms each mark before release.

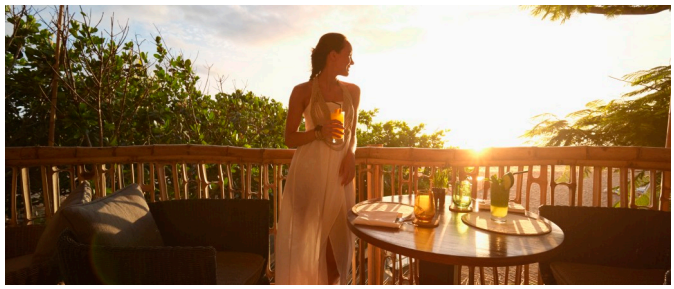
IV · THREE WAYS TO SEE IT

By coast, by forest, or both

	THE PACIFIC COAST	THE WILD INTERIOR	BOTH · THE CONTRAST
Where you sleep	Beach villas and resort suites	Rainforest lodges and hot-spring villas	A Papagayo suite, then a jungle bungalow
Reach	Guanacaste, Nicoya, the south Pacific	Pacuare, Arenal, Monteverde, Osa	Papagayo, then the Osa Peninsula
Pace	Whales, kayaks, long lunches, sunsets	Early walks, rivers, big dinners	Slow, then wild
Getting around	4x4 with a driver who knows the rivers	Small planes and private transfers	One flight across the country
Suits	Families, friends, beach lovers	First-timers, wildlife lovers	Couples, honeymoons, mixed groups
Nights	7–14	8–12	4 + 4
From	`$[____] pp`	`$[____] pp`	`$[____] pp`



By boat, where the road gives up



Sundowners above the canopy

The linger-o-meter

The same small country at three speeds. What each adds, and what you miss without it.

7

DAYS · ONE COAST

Arenal and one beach, done properly.

You miss: the Osa, and the other ocean.

10

DAYS · VOLCANO, CLOUD & WILD

River, volcano and rainforest, by small plane.

You miss: the Caribbean, and the turtles.

14

DAYS · COAST TO COAST

Turtles, volcano, cloud forest, Pacific. The whole country.

You miss: nothing but the cows on the runway.

LINGER LONGER *"Fly over the bad roads, drive the beautiful ones. I learned which is which so you don't have to." — J. W.*

Two Oceans, One Volcano

JW-CR-C01 · 12 DAYS · TORTUGUERO · ARENAL · MONTEVERDE · NOSARA

I KEEP GOING BACK
since 1991



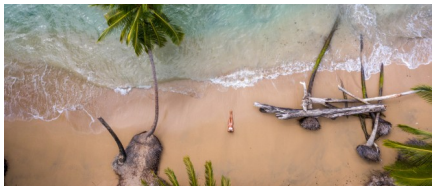
S San José · 1 Tortuguero · 2 Arenal · 3 Monteverde · 4 Nosara. Small plane to the Caribbean, private driver for the rest.



Caribbean side, slower still



Cloud-forest detail



Empty beach, full tank

Days 1–3	**Tortuguero.** Fly in over the canals. Turtles on the beach at night in season, caimans in the creeks by day.
Days 4–6	**Arenal.** Hot springs, hanging bridges and the volcano at dawn, if the clouds allow.
Days 7–8	**Monteverde.** Into the cloud forest for quetzals, and a night walk for the frogs.
Days 9–11	**Nosara.** Beach, yoga, a sea kayak, and nowhere you have to be.
Day 12	**Home.** Out through Liberia.

WHO IT SUITS

First-timers, families with kids, and anyone who wants the whole country without the long drives.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 11 nights

TIME REWARDED

Add the Osa for a fourteen-day coast-to-coast: [__] off the second week.

TR-CRC-JW-F-0001

QR

Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Go to Tortuguero first. After a day on the canals, nothing else on the trip will feel like traffic." — J. W.*

Volcano, Cloud & Wild

JW-CR-W01 · 10 DAYS · SAN JOSÉ · PACUARE · ARENAL · OSA · SMALL PLANES

I'LL KNOW SOON
well worth the visit



S San José · 1 Pacuare River · 2 Arenal · 3 Osa Peninsula. One raft, two small planes, no wrong turns.



Class III to IV, and that's the warm-up



Cloud-forest detail



Humpbacks off the south Pacific coast

Day 1	**San José.** Land, sleep, eat well.
Days 2–3	**Pacuare.** Raft in to the lodge. There is no road, which is the point.
Days 4–6	**Arenal.** Hot springs, hanging bridges, the volcano at dawn.
Days 7–9	**The Osa.** Corcovado on foot, the Pacific by boat, whales in season.
Day 10	**Home.** Small plane to San José, connect out.

WHO IT SUITS

First-timers, families with kids eight and up, and wildlife lovers.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 9 nights

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night in the Osa: [__].

WAN-CRW-JW-F-0001

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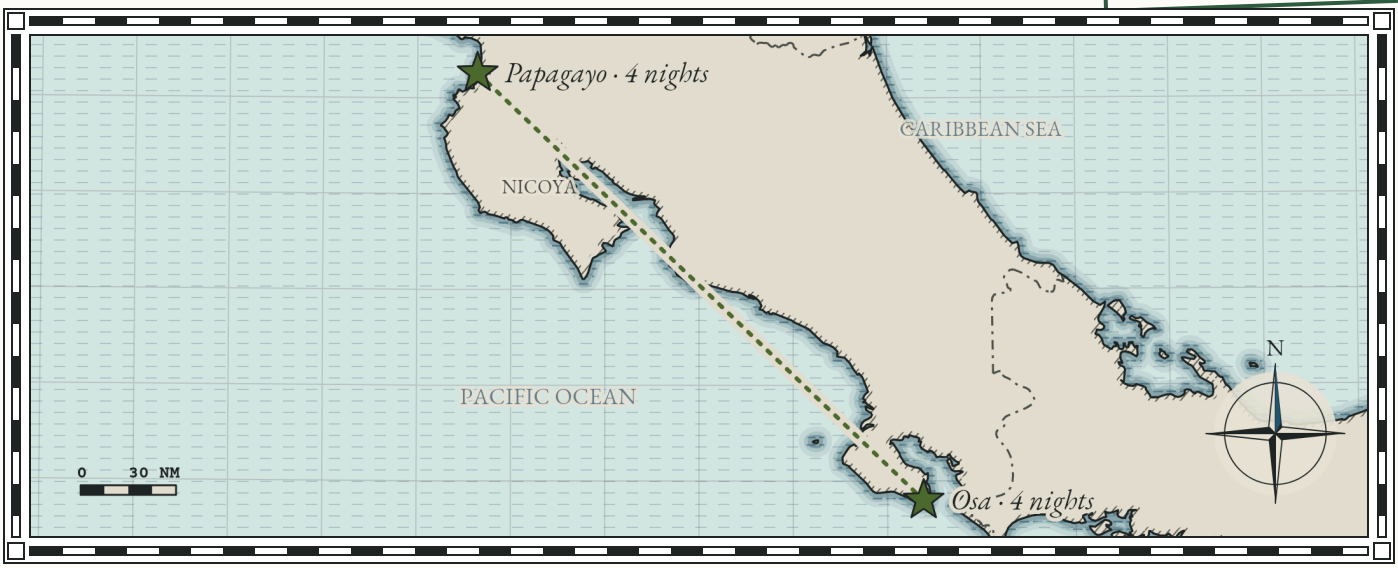
Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Take the dawn walk in Corcovado. The forest is loudest before breakfast, and so are the macaws." — J. W.*

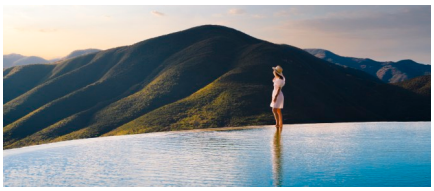
The Contrast

JW-CON-C01 · 4 NIGHTS PAPAGAYO, THEN 4 NIGHTS IN THE OSA · 9 DAYS

I KEEP GOING BACK
the James Wild way



Papagayo, four nights · then one small-plane hop south to the Osa Peninsula



The other kind of long way round



Everyone on one terrace



Where the forest meets the Pacific

Days 1–4	**Papagayo.** Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo. Calm bays, a surf day by boat, long dinners.
Day 5	**Fly south.** Over the Nicoya and down the coast to Puerto Jiménez.
Days 5–8	**The Osa.** Lapa Rios: rainforest at the door, the Pacific below.
Day 9	**Home.** Back via San José or Liberia.

WHO IT SUITS

Couples, honeymooners, and anyone who wants polish first and mud second.

FROM

$[_____] pp · 8 nights

THE CONTRAST RATE

Both stays priced together: [__].

CON-CR-JW-F-0001

QR

Scan for the live animated chart of this route.

LINGER LONGER *"Good journeys have seams. Polish, then mud. You should feel the change." — J. W.*

Small planes, big rivers

Costa Rica is small on the map and large on the ground. The trick is knowing when to fly, when to drive and when to let the river decide.

PHOTO TO LICENSE · GETTY 1695657254

Small planes

DOMESTIC FLIGHTS · DIRT AND PAVED STRIPS · 20–60 MIN

Two domestic airlines, SANSA and Costa Rica Green Airways, link San José to the coasts: Nosara, Tambor, Tamarindo, Quepos, Golfito, Puerto Jiménez, Drake Bay and Tortuguero. Some strips are paved now. Some are not. The cows have mostly moved on.

PHOTO TO LICENSE · GETTY 1297975323

4x4, with a driver

PRIVATE TRANSFERS · RIVER FORDS INCLUDED

A good driver knows which rivers to cross and which to admire from the bank. We learned the hard way, so you can learn the easy way.



Boats

TORTUGUERO CANALS · OSA · OLLIE'S POINT

Some of the best of Costa Rica has no road at all. Tortuguero is reached by canal, Ollie's Point by sea, parts of the Osa by panga.



Rafts

PACUARE RIVER · CLASS III–IV

The only way into Pacuare Lodge is down the river. Your bags go by road; you go by raft. Nobody has ever asked to swap.

In 1991 the runway check was simple: one low pass to move the cows, one to make sure they stayed moved. These days there's a windsock and, usually, no cows.
— J. Wild

Seven stays, coast to cloud forest



1 Nayara Springs · 2 Lapa Rios Lodge · 3 Pacuare Lodge · 4 Origins Lodge · 5 Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo · 6 Hacienda AltaGracia · 7 Harmony Hotel Nosara

> *Split it in two: one night in a jungle lodge is worth three in a city hotel. Two nights minimum anywhere you have to fly to.*
> *— J. Wild*

Room counts and facilities from the properties' published listings; confirm with each property. Partner photography to follow.

1 Nayara Springs

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

ARENAL · LA FORTUNA

Thirty-five adults-only villas facing the volcano, each with a private plunge pool fed by mineral hot springs.

Best for: Couples and anyone who likes a hot soak with a view.

2 Lapa Rios Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

OSA PENINSULA · CABO MATAPALO

Seventeen bungalows on a private rainforest reserve where the Golfo Dulce meets the Pacific. Whales from the veranda in season.

Best for: Wildlife lovers and the properly curious.

3 Pacuare Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

PACUARE RIVER

Twenty suites and villas in the forest, reached by whitewater raft. The Canopy Suite has its own suspension bridge.

Best for: Families with teens and adventurous couples.

4 Origins Lodge

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

RINCÓN DE LA VIEJA · TENORIO

Seven rooms and villas with views to the volcanoes and Lake Nicaragua, and wood-fired hot tubs of their own.

Best for: Honeymooners and anyone hiding from the world.

5 Four Seasons Peninsula Papagayo

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

GUANACASTE · PAPAGAYO

182 rooms, suites and villas on a forested peninsula between two beaches, newly renovated with plunge-pool canopy suites.

Best for: Families, three generations and surf by boat.

6 Hacienda AltaGracia

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

PÉREZ ZELEDÓN · TALAMANCA

Fifty casitas on a coffee and horse estate in the southern mountains, from Auberge Resorts.

Best for: Riders, coffee lovers and a quiet reset.

7 Harmony Hotel Nosara

I'LL KNOW SOON — well worth the visit

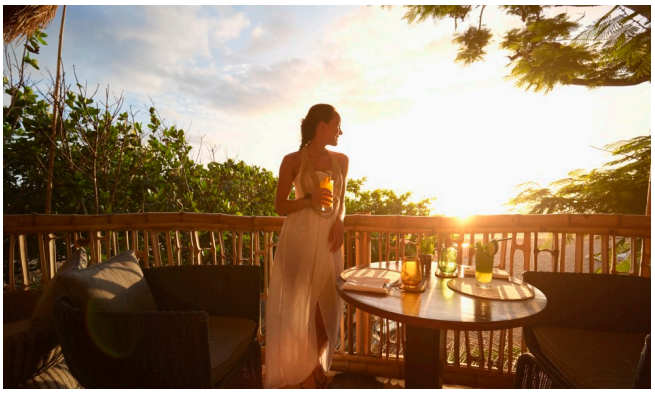
NOSARA · PLAYA GUIONES

Twenty-four rooms and two villas a short walk through the trees to Guiones, with an open-air yoga pavilion.

Best for: Surfers, yogis and slow mornings.

VII · LINGER

Slower is the whole point



Sundowners above the canopy

Most Costa Rica regrets are about driving, not money. People try to see six regions in eight days and spend most of it behind a truck full of pineapples. We'd rather you stayed.

That's why we plan two or three bases, fly between the far ones, and reward staying longer rather than booking sooner.

Three nights or don't unpack. The first day you hear the howlers. The third day you stop noticing them. That's when you've arrived.
— J. Wild

TIME REWARDED

Coast to Coast

Fourteen days, Caribbean to Pacific: [__] off the second week.

TR-CRC-JW-F-0001

WORTH ANOTHER NIGHT

A fourth night in the Osa

[offer to confirm with the property]

WAN-CRW-JW-F-0001

ON THE HORIZON

The 1990s run

Costa Rica, Nicaragua and Panama by board, the way we mapped it: early-planner savings of [__].

OTH-CA-JW-F-0001

Codes are tied to your Folio ID so your advisor sees which offer you chose.

VIII · THE LEDGER

The Costa Rica entries

ENTRY	PLACE	MARK	MARGIN NOTE
L-301	Corcovado · Osa Peninsula	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*The wildest walk in Central America. Bring socks you don't love.*
L-302	Tortuguero · Caribbean coast	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*No roads, all canals. Turtles keep the night shift.*
L-303	Monteverde cloud forest	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*Go at dawn for quetzals, after dark for frogs.*
L-304	Nosara · Nicoya	I KEEP GOING BACK since 1991	*Still the friendliest beach town on the coast.*
L-305	Lapa Rios · Osa Peninsula	I'LL KNOW SOON well worth the visit	*On the list for my next run south.*
L-306	Nayara Springs · Arenal	I'LL KNOW SOON well worth the visit	*Hot springs in your own villa. Asking for a friend.*

Sample entries for layout. Every stamp is confirmed by James before release.

Rules of the Road

01 **If in doubt, don't cross the river.** Rule learned in 1992. Paid for in 1992.

02 **Fly the far ones.** A 40-minute flight beats a nine-hour drive, every time.

03 **Dawn is the good part.** Surf, birds and wildlife all keep early hours.

04 **Check the rafters.** For hornets. Old habit. Good habit.

Words we've struck out

~~UNDISCOVERED~~ — The surfers found it in the sixties. The Ticos found it long before that.

~~OFF THE BEATEN PATH~~ — In 1991, there was no path. Now there's a very good one, and we'll take you past the end of it.

~~PARADISE~~ — Paradise doesn't have hornets. Costa Rica is better than paradise.

What to know, and what not to expect

Getting there

Two international airports: Juan Santamaría (SJO) near San José, and Daniel Oduber (LIR) at Liberia for Guanacaste and the Nicoya. Arrive in daylight if you can.

At the border

US citizens need a passport valid for the length of the stay and proof of onward travel; stays of up to 180 days without a visa are allowed at the officer's discretion. The $29 departure tax is usually included in the airfare `[confirm per airline]`.

Getting around

Fly between the far regions with SANSA or Costa Rica Green Airways, or by private charter. Drive the short legs with a private driver. Luggage limits on small planes are strict; pack soft bags.

Pack

Reef-safe sunscreen, a light rain jacket, quick-dry everything, closed shoes for muddy trails, binoculars, a headlamp, and a little patience for the wildlife.

What not to expect

~~ON-TIME ARRIVALS~~	Roads, rivers and cows run on their own schedule.
~~CHEAP~~	It was, in 1991. Well, now…
~~A DRY FOREST~~	It's called a rainforest for a reason.
~~CROWDED LINE-UPS~~	Not where we send you, and not at dawn.
~~HORNET-FREE RAFTERS~~	Mostly. Look up before you sit down.

Straight answers

Will I see a sloth? Almost certainly. Getting one to look at you is another matter.

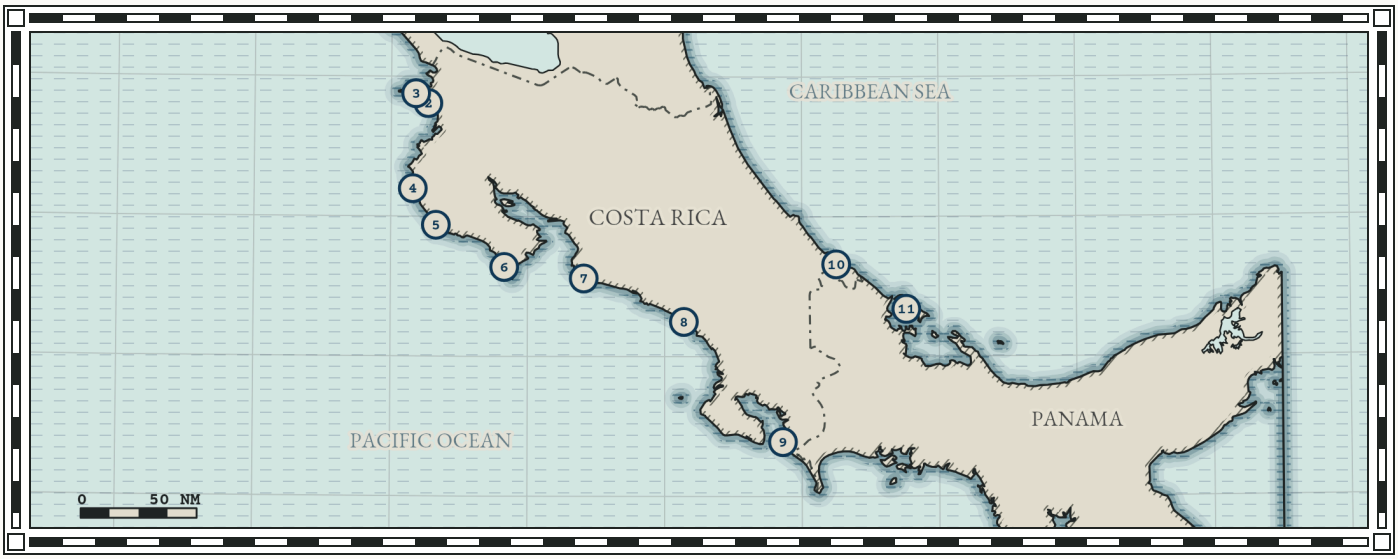
Can I drive myself? You can. I did, for years. Hire a driver.

Children? A great fit. Ages for rafting and ziplines `[confirm per operator]`.

I KEEP GOING BACK
mapped 1990s

If you came to surf

Most of this guide is about the forest and the animals. This page is for the board-carriers. In the early nineties, Adventure Expeditions charted the surf of Central America one dirt road at a time, from Nicaragua to Panama. These are the breaks I still send people to. Ask for The Long Way Round, our 14-day surf run from Liberia to Pavones.



Positions approximate. Sizes, seasons and access change: surf with a local guide, respect the line-up; some breaks are reached only by boat or across private land.

01 Popoyo · NICARAGUA · RIVAS
Reef, point and beach peaks with near-constant offshore winds off Lake Nicaragua. The outer reef is for experts.

02 Witch's Rock · SANTA ROSA NATIONAL PARK
Roca Bruja: a rock and rivermouth wave that can barrel, about 45 minutes by permitted boat from Playas del Coco.

03 Ollie's Point · SANTA ROSA NATIONAL PARK
A long right-hand point, best low to mid tide. Boat only, park fee paid.

04 Playa Negra · NEAR TAMARINDO
A reef right that tubes at low to mid tide. Get there before the wind does.

05 Nosara · Playa Guiones · NICOYA PENINSULA
Peeling sand-bottom peaks with a friendly inside. The best place in the country to learn.

06 Santa Teresa · Mal País · NICOYA PENINSULA
Rock-ledge rights and lefts that barrel on the right tide; left points at the south end.

07 Playa Hermosa · NEAR JACÓ
A powerful multi-peak beach break that fires in August.

08 Dominical · SOUTH PACIFIC
Punchy beach break below the jungle, with whales offshore in season.

09 Pavones · GOLFO DULCE
One of the longest lefts in the world, rides up to about a kilometre on a south-southwest swell.

10 Salsa Brava · PUERTO VIEJO · CARIBBEAN
A hollow right over shallow reef, the country's heaviest wave. November to March, experts only.

11 Bocas del Toro · PANAMA · CARIBBEAN
Reef breaks at Paunch, Bluff, Carenero and Silverbacks, best in the northern winter.

12 Santa Catalina · PANAMA · VERAGUAS
La Punta, a rocky point that breaks left and right and gets big. March to October.

FROM THE ORIGINAL LOGBOOK

1991
Wrong turn outside Liberia. Found a perfect empty point. Kept the wrong turn.

1992
Drove into a river at high tide. The river won. We waded to the far bank; the car stayed for supper.

1993
The pilot did one low pass to clear the cows, a second to clear the cows that came back, then landed.

Every year
Before sitting down: check the rafters for hornets. Then sit down.

Words you'll hear on the road

Pura vida

Pure life. Hello, goodbye, thank you, no worries, and the national philosophy.

Tico, Tica

A Costa Rican. Named, so the story goes, for a fondness for the diminutive "-tico".

Soda

A small family restaurant. Order the casado, the plate of the day.

Green season

The polite name for the rainy season, May to November. The forest's favourite.

Terciopelo

The fer-de-lance. Velvet by name, not by nature. Stay on the trail.

Panga

A small open boat. Your ride to Ollie's Point, and a few lodges.

Tico time

Like regular time, but relaxed. Plan for it, and you'll love it.

Howler

The monkey that wakes you at 4.30 a.m. Louder than any alarm, and free.

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COLOPHON

Set in Bodoni Moda, Libre Caslon Display and Text and Courier Prime, with James's signature in Mrs Saint Delafield. Designed and ledgered by James Wild & Co., Miami. Field Guide No. 03, Edition 2027.

YOUR TRAVELER FOLIO · JW-F-0001

Your journey, in your hand

When I'd like to go	
Who's coming	
Coast, forest or both	☐ The Pacific coast ☐ The wild interior ☐ The Contrast
The coast I circled	☐ Pacific ☐ Caribbean ☐ I'd like the surf guide too
Something to celebrate	

I KNOW A PLACE · THE WEEKLY LETTER

One place a week, from James's own book

New lodges, quiet breaks and the odd secret we don't print here. You're already on the list.

A LAST WORD FROM JAMES

Jane, that's Costa Rica as I've known it since 1991, from a stalled car in a river to a hot spring under a volcano. Circle what moves you, cross out what doesn't, and send it back to me. I'll read every mark and call you with a plan built around them. I've already taken every wrong turn in the country. You don't have to.

Til our next expedition,

James

JAMES PAPAGNO · CHIEF EXPEDITION OFFICER

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MAPS Engraved plates drawn by James Wild & Co. from Natural Earth public-domain data; surf-break positions approximate.
HISTORY Adventure Expeditions and the surf breaks mapped 1991–1994: from James Papagno's own logbooks and recollection. Some rivers may remember it differently.
SOURCES Arrivals: ICT figures via Wikipedia (1991) and La Nación (2025). Biodiversity and protected areas: Embassy of Costa Rica; SINAC. Army abolished 1948: Constitution of Costa Rica, Art. 12. Seasons and surf: The Surf Atlas, CR Surf, Surfer Today, Tourism Panama; turtles: ACTO/SINAC. Entry: US Department of State. Domestic airlines: SANSA; La Nación. Stays: Forbes Travel Guide, Black Tomato, i-escape, Four Seasons, Virtuoso, Timbuktu, Costa Rica Experts; confirm with each property before booking.
SMALL PRINT Prices, offers and departures shown as [__] are to be confirmed and subject to availability. Seasons are guidance only. Ledger marks are samples until confirmed. © 2026 James Wild & Co. All rights reserved.



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FIELD GUIDE NO. 03
COSTA RICA · THE LONG WAY ROUND
EDITION 2027